

satellite television enabled by a dish antenna that always stays locked on to the satellite of your choice are not exactly very helpful in preventing accidents, traffic jams, and the destruction of our environment.

Hybrid cars are being talked about a lot, and are looking promising for the near future, to help us depend less on oil.

Fuels

As alternative fuel technology goes, almost everything has been tried. However, recently, BMW released news of its Hydrogen 7 Series. These cars run on a hybrid of hydrogen and regular petroleum-based fuel. The difference is that instead of using the alternative fuel to produce electricity and then power the car, the Hydrogen 7 Series actually uses liquid hydrogen as a fuel in an internal combustion engine—actually burning hydrogen to power the engine directly.

A few lucky folks recently got to test drive one, and gave it very favourable reviews online. The shortcomings (yes, there will always be these) are the fact that currently, hydrogen refill stations are few and far between, and the fuel economy actually works out more expensive than petrol! BMW, however, blames this on a not-yet-perfected engine, which they promise to work upon, and the fact that no one wants hydrogen just yet! The theory is that once the demand increases, supply will become more prevalent and also cheaper.

The promising fact is that BMW is already working on a “hydrogen-only” combustion

engine, which basically means “no petrol required”—which is precisely what we need!

This is just one example of alternative fuel technologies being looked at. Space doesn't permit discussing them all, but the idea is catching on as people realise that in 40 years or so, the average person will not be able to afford petroleum-based fuel, due to lack of supply. What's good about the research in this field is that we only seem to be considering “clean” fuels—the type that will not destroy the environment—not as much as petroleum-based fuels do, at least. Basically, you'll still be stuck in traffic snarls, but you'll be able to breathe for a change!

Adaptive Cruise Control

Currently, this term is used for technologies found in luxury sedans that monitor how close you are to a car in front of you, and use acceleration or braking to maintain a safe distance. Different companies have added various features to this “awareness” that adaptive cruise control seems to bring about in cars. Toyota / Lexus have scrapped the older radar method for optical sensors that will detect and avoid obstacles—such as other cars, pedestrians, a large cat that decides to cross just as you approach... of course, handling is left to the driver, but the brake is activated in order to prevent collision. This is more a collision prevention technology than cruise control, but the idea is the same.

A whole lot of manufacturers, including Mercedes Benz, Lexus, Audi, BMW, and many more, have started providing cutting-edge technologies such as automatic parking, advanced

